

Final Report Assessment

Tom & Jerry & Sons, Fruit and Veg Ltd Cloud Migration

A Microsoft Azure-Centric Hybrid Architecture with Dell, Cisco, and Palo Alto Networks
On-Premises Infrastructure

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Abstract

This report proposes a migration architecture for Tom & Jerry & Sons, Fruit and Veg Ltd, using Microsoft technologies and cloud infrastructure, with a focus on security and on-premises hardware.

Key components include Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management for inventories and HR, Salesforce Customer 365 for CRM, Microsoft 365 Business Premium for productivity, and MuleSoft Anypoint Platform for integration. The infrastructure leverages Azure Hybrid Benefit, Azure SQL Managed Instance, and Azure Virtual Desktop for IaaS and PaaS delivery. On-site hardware includes Dell PowerEdge R660 servers, Dell PowerVault ME5012 storage, Dell OptiPlex Micro thin clients, Cisco Catalyst switches, and a Palo Alto Networks firewall for legacy workload support and Azure connectivity.

The research discusses this architecture in terms of delivery methods, migration issues, and security threats. Comparing solutions for their appropriateness to the organization's scale. The findings show that the chosen security and ERP layers are aligned with the business goals, but the enterprise-level technologies selected might not be cost-efficient for a single-site wholesaler with roughly 200 people.

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1. Introduction

The National Institute of Standards and Technology describes cloud computing as a shared pool of programmable computing resources that may be rapidly deployed with minimal administration effort and provided as a service over the Internet (Mell & Grance, 2011), also described this concept as computing becoming available as a metered utility (Armbrust et al., 2010). Tom & Jerry & Sons is at the intersection of this theory and a difficult legacy IT environment, which includes a modern but siloed CRM system, ageing payroll, HR, and stock databases with limited interoperability, and an accounting system so old that data is still sent between systems manually.

This report delineates a specific architecture for cloud migration, comprising Microsoft Azure and Dynamics 365 as the core, Salesforce for customer relationship management (CRM), MuleSoft as the integration framework, and a retained on-premises layer utilising Dell, Cisco, and Palo Alto Networks hardware for workloads that are not yet prepared for cloud transition (Cisco, 2026; Dell Technologies, 2023; Microsoft Azure, 2026; Palo Alto Networks, 2025; Salesforce, 2024). Each succeeding section will assess an element of this architecture in relation to the necessary technical and legal issues, encompassing delivery model theory, virtualization, migration feasibility, interoperability, security, and risk (Mell & Grance, 2011).

2. Critical Analysis of Cloud Service Models and Virtualization

2.1 Mapping the Architecture to IaaS, PaaS, and SaaS

NIST's three-model taxonomy offers a clear framework for this proposal (Mell & Grance, 2011).

At the Software as a Service (SaaS) layer, key applications include Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management, Salesforce Customer 365 (Lutz, 2025), and Microsoft 365 Business Premium, with Microsoft and Salesforce managing patching, uptime, and infrastructure (Microsoft, 2026a)

In the Platform as a Service (PaaS) layer, MuleSoft Anypoint Platform provides a cloud-based integration suite for API management (MuleSoft, 2026a), while Azure SQL Managed Instance is a fully managed database platform, where Microsoft handles maintenance and backups, allowing the company to retain database control (Microsoft, 2026b).

At the Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS) layer, Azure Hybrid Benefit-licensed virtual machines and Azure Dedicated Hosts deliver single-tenant computing resources that need configuration and security from the company or its partners (Microsoft, 2026c). Azure Virtual Desktop serves as a managed desktop-as-a-service, where Microsoft manages the infrastructure while the company focuses on desktop images and user assignments (Microsoft, 2026d).

2.2 The SaaS Layer: Dynamics 365, Salesforce, and Microsoft 365

Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management overcomes the challenges of many payroll, HR, and inventory systems by combining operational data on a single platform with embedded automation. But this requires organisations to adopt Microsoft's data architecture and update schedule and to relinquish long-standing customisations, as explained in Section 3.5 (Lutz, 2025).

Salesforce Customer 365 consolidates customer records to remove different CRM systems. Salesforce's acquisition of MuleSoft has enabled integration with legacy systems, and a holistic strategy has been achieved, with the ROI of API-led integration being three years in the low hundreds of percent (although such stats should be taken as indicative (Luk, 2025)).

With a single subscription, Microsoft 365 Business Premium helps boost office productivity, Teams communication, and OneDrive storage (Microsoft, 2026a). Also, Azure Virtual Desktop licensing usually necessitates a Microsoft 365 license for numerous desktop environments (Microsoft, 2026d). Therefore, it is logical to standardise on Business Premium to install virtual desktops, as mentioned in section 2.3.

2.3 The Integration and Database Layer: MuleSoft and Azure SQL Managed Instance

MuleSoft Anypoint Platform uses API-led connectivity. API-led connectivity includes System APIs for legacy databases, Process APIs for reusable business functions, and Experience APIs for formatting results for new SaaS front ends (CurieTech, 2026). This methodology remedies the deficiencies of manual data transfer and enables legacy systems to be modernised without having to be replaced (MuleSoft, 2026).

For payroll and HR databases that are connected with MuleSoft, Azure SQL Managed Instance is the preferred choice because of its nearly complete SQL Server compatibility, and it removes IT hassles such as patching and upgrades (Microsoft, 2026b). It also offers Azure Hybrid Benefit, which allows the reuse of current SQL Server licenses with active Software Assurance, which considerably improves migration economics (Microsoft, 2026b).

2.4 Distributed Parallel Computing, and Multicore Hardware

The architecture is based on the elastic architecture of the data centers of Azure and On-site Dell PowerEdge R660 servers using distributed and parallel computing techniques (Microsoft, 2023). This method distributes the jobs across nodes connected via a network. It also provides robustness to component failure. Parallel computing makes use of many processing units for the same job. Dell PowerEdge R660 is a 1U dual-socket server that can be equipped with up to two Intel Xeon Scalable processors with up to 64 cores and 8 TB of DDR5 memory (Dell Technologies, 2023), enabling the firm to efficiently run numerous segregated older virtual machines.

Furthermore, Azure's infrastructure and the company's network core are built on multicore concepts (Microsoft, 2026e). The proposed Cisco Catalyst 9500 switches will provide the backbone that connects legacy databases, clients, and the Azure gateway. Using multicore x86 CPUs and custom silicon, they deliver non-blocking switching capacity of up to 12.8 terabits per second and represent the extension of multicore architecture into the network fabric (Cisco, 2025).

2.5 Virtualization: Hypervisors, Dedicated Hosts, and the Legacy Boundary

Through virtualization, physical cores in Dell PowerEdge R660 can be dedicated to older applications in isolated environments, and physical infrastructure in Azure can be converted into virtual machines for tenants (Bisht, 2026). This proposal suggests the use of Azure Dedicated Hosts for dealing with sensitive workloads, as these are physical servers that are fully dedicated to a single enterprise, thereby guaranteeing compliance with co-tenancy regulations (Microsoft, 2026c).

The Dell PowerEdge R660 is also the perfect host for older accounting software because it can isolate the outdated operating system without the need for additional physical purchases. It is natively integrated with Hyper-V, VMware ESXi, and other hypervisors (Bisht, 2026).

Virtualization doesn't magically make unsupported programs work – they remain unpatched even when virtualized. Virtualization and Azure Dedicated Hosts instead provide isolation and a regulated maintenance boundary around threats (Rosquin, 2026).

2.6 Comparative Justification: Why These Vendors, and Where the Choice Is Contestable

The products presented are not the only products that are possible. MuleSoft is more costly, starting at roughly \$80,000 per year, while alternatives such as Boomi and Workato are less expensive for similar integration (ARIOX, 2026). MuleSoft's connectivity to Salesforce Customer 365 offers distinct benefits that decrease risks through native connectors and a shared roadmap that a Salesforce-agnostic platform like Boomi might not provide (TeamCentral, 2026).

The Cisco Catalyst 9500 might be too expensive for what we require, as the Catalyst 9300 is more appropriate for mid-sized organisations and could save money (Ben-CCIE, 2026). The board should consider both ideas before deciding.

The Palo Alto PA-440 is more suitable for our scale than the bigger PA-5000 or PA-7000 series (Palo Alto, 2026). Dedicated hosts in Azure are charged for their entire capacity, regardless of usage; therefore, segregated VM sizes may be a more economical initial step (Microsoft, 2026c).

Finally, selecting Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management with Salesforce Customer 365 is a deliberate choice to divide CRM and operations, which comes with both advantages and complexities (Salesforce, 2024).

3. Evaluation of Migration Feasibility and Challenges

3.1 The Legacy Estate Mapped to the Proposed Architecture

The migration of the CRM system is the least controversial portion of the strategy. Salesforce Customer 365 is a mature, cloud-native SaaS with the lowest technical risk. But payroll, HR, and stock data are more difficult to migrate because of the age and poor interoperability of databases (Sauve, 2021). The suggested solution is to have MuleSoft expose each historical database as a System API, with Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management as the new system of record (MuleSoft, 2026a). Any remaining database segments will be housed in an Azure SQL Managed Instance (Microsoft, 2026b).

The oldest accounting software is the hardest situation and is intentionally left out of the cloud tier in this proposal. It is hosted on a Dell PowerEdge R660 server, virtualized and separated from other workloads, with its data stored on a directly attached Dell PowerVault ME5012 storage array rather than being transferred to Azure. The ME5012 is a dual-controller, SAS-based array that supports FIPS 140-2 Level 2-certified self-encrypting drives and built-in Advanced Data Protection Technology distributed RAID, and it supports asynchronous replication to a second ME5 array for disaster recovery (Dell Technologies, 2022), giving this

retained legacy workload a level of data protection that it almost certainly lacks today (Skywardtel, 2023).

3.2 Interoperability: MuleSoft as the Missing Layer

The brief explains how manual data transfer needs people to perform duties that should be automated by an integration platform like MuleSoft. MuleSoft's API-led connectivity strategy includes pre-built connectors and a standard data transformation language to enable access to data from legacy systems for modern SaaS and cloud applications without replacing the legacy systems (CurieTech, 2026). The ideal case is to have MuleSoft in place prior to the Dynamics 365 and Salesforce migrations, so that manual data transfers are eliminated immediately, prior to the slower database migrations.

3.3 Legal and Safety Implications

Payroll and HR data are personal data under the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018. Transferring this data to a non-UK cloud provider would likely be considered a restricted transfer, requiring a three-step assessment and appropriate safeguards like the International Data Transfer Agreement (Austin, 2026).

Azure Dedicated Hosts and Azure SQL Managed Instance can be deployed in specific regions, allowing the company to control data residency rather than relying solely on provider assurances (Microsoft Azure, 2026f).

Palo Alto PA-440: Provides network security with machine-learning threat prevention and Layer 7 inspection. This device creates an encrypted IPSec VPN tunnel to Azure, ensuring that all traffic between the legacy databases and the cloud remains secure (Palo Alto, 2024).

In addition, the Azure Hybrid Benefit has compliance issues; a license can only be active in one place at a time outside of a set migration window. Therefore, maintaining an accurate license inventory is critical to avoiding non-compliance during migration (Microsoft, 2025).

3.4 On-Demand Scaling, Capacity Planning and SLAs

Through the Azure Hybrid Benefit, customers can use their existing Windows Server and SQL Server licenses with active Software Assurance for Azure virtual machines and Azure SQL Managed Instance (Microsoft, 2025). Together with additional savings, this can cut license expenses by 40 to 55 percent (Andersen, 2026). IT teams need a precise inventory of on-premises licenses to efficiently manage costs and scaling for Dynamics 365 and Azure services (Hollander, 2022).

With Azure Virtual Desktop's Windows Enterprise multi-session functionality, several users can share a single virtual machine, allowing flexibility in desktop provisioning as headcount expands without having to purchase new PCs (Microsoft, 2026d). Dell OptiPlex Micro thin clients are suggested for their affordable cost and reduced data loss risks (Steinberg, 2026).

Additionally, it is also important to get formal Service Level Agreements (SLAs) from Microsoft and Salesforce. Such SLAs should include guaranteed uptime, incident response times for Dynamics 365 and Salesforce Customer 365, and a defined procedure for scaling entitlements so there are no surprises with licensing as the organization scales (Jeffery, 2026).

3.5 Cost and Proportionality

A specification exercise might easily slide in the direction of recommending the most capable products rather than the most suitable. The board's got to address this before they sign anything. While each of MuleSoft, the Catalyst 9500, and Azure Dedicated Hosts might be justified on their own, collectively they produce a system that is considerably more costly and complex than what a two-hundred-employee, single-site wholesaler requires (Thomsen, 2026).

Rather than approving the complete architecture all at once, a phased approval procedure that includes a total cost of ownership comparison of MuleSoft vs. Boomi and Catalyst 9500 vs. Catalyst 9300 is a more sensible approach.

The Cisco Catalyst 9500 presents a substantial danger of over-specification since it is intended for high-throughput situations that this organization does not require (Ben-CCIE, 2026).

Similarly, Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management targets large, multi-entity organisations, whereas Dynamics 365 Business Central is more suitable for a single-site, expanding business at a cheaper price point (Sikich, 2025).

This scale goes well with Palo Alto PA-440, which is meant for smaller organisations (Palo Alto, 2024). The Dell PowerEdge R660 also makes sense given its high-core-count design, not just for current workloads, but for future consolidation of virtual machines (Dell Technologies, 2023).

4. Security and Risk Assessment

4.1 The Threat Landscape

The ENISA cloud risk taxonomy divides cloud-specific risk factors into three major areas: policy and organizational risks, technical risks, and legal concerns. It emphasises two major technological risks: lack of isolation between co-tenants and compromises of the management interfaces (ENISA, 2009). To address concerns about isolation for the company's most sensitive workloads, the design leverages Azure Dedicated Hosts. This means that the virtual machines of other customers are not assigned to the same physical server (Microsoft, 2026c). The accounting system also runs on Dell hardware owned by the company, rather than shared cloud infrastructure.

4.2 Shared Responsibility Across a Hybrid Estate

A hybrid architecture divides responsibility among three parties instead of two. Microsoft and Salesforce are responsible for securing their SaaS applications and the infrastructure below them (Keohane, 2026). The organization manages identity, access, and data in cloud environments. The design importantly places the duty for physically securing and patching the Dell PowerEdge R660, PowerVault ME5012, Cisco Catalyst switching and Palo Alto firewall squarely on the company's premises – and not on cloud providers, who have no part in this layer of security (Fortinet, 2026). The suggested way to keep control of the on-premises perimeter constant and auditable is to use centralised policy administration with Panorama or Strata Cloud Manager (Palo Alto, 2026).

4.3 Data Loss and Backup

Azure SQL Managed Instance is a PaaS service that includes automated backups and offers 99.99% availability (Microsoft, 2026b). The Dell PowerVault ME5012 offers hardware-level snapshots, asynchronous replication to a secondary array, and AES-256 encryption on self-encrypting drives (Dell Technologies, 2022). This improves the recovery posture of maintained legacy accounting data to be on par with cloud-hosted workloads, rather than a possible weak link.

4.4 Provider Failure and Vendor Lock-in

The combination of the Software as a Service (SaaS) and Platform as a Service (PaaS) layers with Microsoft and Salesforce brings potential risks of typical cloud outages and vendor lock-in (Check Point, 2025). Microsoft Hybrid Benefit also has license mobility terms associated with it, which over time link the company's cost model to specific Microsoft licensing agreements (Hollander, 2022). As a deliberate move, the corporation has maintained an on-premises layer to reduce these risks. The accounting system is on Dell hardware owned by the corporation, so it is immune to any disruptions that might affect Microsoft or Salesforce. However, this would not stop disruption to access for Dynamics 365, Salesforce, and Azure Virtual Desktop elsewhere in the enterprise (Thomas, 2026).

4.5 Practical Recommendations

- Migrate to MuleSoft to eliminate manual data transfer, then deploy Salesforce Customer 365, followed by Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management, and Azure SQL Managed Instance for payroll, HR, and inventory. Keep the Dell PowerEdge R660 until replaced.
- Configure Azure Dedicated Hosts and Azure SQL Managed Instance in a UK Azure region, and perform an ICO-style transfer risk assessment before any transmission of personal data from the Dell PowerVault ME5012 (Microsoft Azure, 2026f).
- Ensure that all traffic from the on-premises legacy layer to Azure is routed via the Palo Alto PA-440 encrypted IPsec VPN tunnel to avoid unencrypted linkages.
- Track your Azure Hybrid Benefit licenses to ensure you don't violate dual-use throughout the 180-day migration period. Configure replication of PowerVault ME5012 to another

array using automated backups from Azure SQL Managed Instance, but not as a replacement for the other array.

- Compare costs for MuleSoft, Boomi, and Cisco Catalyst before purchasing. Ensure VM sizes meet compliance before committing, and negotiate SLAs with Microsoft and Salesforce for support.

5. Conclusion

This report is a hybrid architecture for Tom & Jerry & Sons with certain important components. At the Software as a Service (SaaS) layer, we are using Dynamics 365 Supply Chain Management, Salesforce Customer 365, and Microsoft 365 Business Premium. The solution's Platform as a Service (PaaS) layer includes MuleSoft Anypoint Platform and Azure SQL Managed Instance, while the Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS) layer includes Azure Hybrid Benefit, Azure Dedicated Hosts and Azure Virtual Desktop. We also have a substantial on-premises footprint with Dell PowerEdge R660 servers and other gear for the one legacy task not yet transferred.

This approach meets the specific requirements from the project brief: MuleSoft automates the data transfers, Dynamics 365 consolidates the databases, and the Dell hardware preserves the legacy accounting system. There are still risks and costs, such as compliance with the UK GDPR and managing on-premises technology, but this hybrid model is a safer route than a full cloud migration or staying with a fragmented system. The company should view these advanced ERP and integration products as intentional choices rather than defaults.

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